number was a taciturn young Ulsterman who would later go on to change the course of Indian history, Captain John Nicholson. Nicholson was not easily impressed, but wrote afterwards to his mother that he ‘never was in the company of more gentleman-like, well-bred men. They are strikingly handsome, as the Afghan sirdars always are, with a great deal of dignity . . . As I looked around the circle I saw both parricides and regicides – the murderer of our envoy was perhaps the least blood-stained of the party.’[37] Nicholson’s colleague Lieutenant Crawford was also taken aback by Akbar Khan’s perfect manners. ‘We met with the kindest reception,’ he wrote later.

> I could not bring myself to believe that the stout, good-humoured, open-hearted looking young man who was making such kind enquiries after our health, and how we had borne the fatigues of the journey, could be the murderer of Macnaghten and the leader of the massacre of our troops . . . He ordered dinner, and sent for Troup and Pottinger to see us; when they arrived the whole of us all sat down to the best dinner I had had for many a month. The Wuzeer chatted and joked away on different subjects during the meal . . . the following morning the arch-fiend sent us an excellent breakfast . . . and he desired a list of our wants, regarding clothes &c might be made out, and that they should be furnished.[38]

One man who received less courteous treatment from the new Wazir was Burnes’s former munshi and intelligence chief Mohan Lal Kashmiri. Akbar Khan had intercepted some of Mohan Lal’s correspondence with the British and had discovered that the munshi had been actively gathering arms and ammunition for Fatteh Jang. In a stark contrast to the treatment extended to the British prisoners, Mohan Lal was immediately thrown into solitary confinement, beaten and later tortured. ‘I was forced to lie down and a couch placed over me on which the people are jumping and are beating me with sticks and tormenting me in a very rude and unmerciful manner,’ Mohan Lal reported in a hastily scribbled and ungrammatical letter that he managed to get smuggled out to Jalalabad. ‘Akbar wants Rs 30,000 from me, says otherwise he will pull out my eyes; all my body has been severely beaten. I cannot promise anything without governments order, but see myself destroyed. All my feet is wounded from bastinadoing.’[39]

A week later, he got word out that his condition had deteriorated: ‘Sometimes I am pinioned and a heavy stone is placed over my back, while red pepper is burnt before my nose and eyes. Sometimes I am bastinadoed. I suffer every imaginable agony. He wants Rs 30,000 out of which he has hitherto to get Rs 12,000 after using me very rudely. The remainder if not paid in the course of ten days, he says he will pull out my eyes and burn my